Understanding your assignment

Practical guide for students | D10-ST

Before starting an assignment, establish what you must do, what knowledge you must demonstrate and how your work will be assessed. Clear expectations help you direct your effort towards the task.

1. Read the complete task

Read the brief, rubric and any linked instructions together. Note the due date, required format, length, submission route and any rules about sources, collaboration or digital tools.

2. Identify the required action

Highlight instruction words such as compare, explain, analyse or evaluate. Check their meaning in this task. An evaluation normally needs a reasoned judgement, rather than only a description.

3. Define the topic and limits

Identify the issue, case, period or context you must address. Write one sentence describing what is included. Check whether you must use particular theories, data or readings.

4. Use the assessment criteria

Read each criterion and the relevant performance descriptions. Ask what evidence in your work would demonstrate it. Note the weighting where provided; do not rely only on the overall word count.

5. Check your interpretation

Make a brief plan and ask a focused question if needed: “I plan to compare both options using cost and risk, then justify a recommendation. Does that address the task?”

6. Turn expectations into a plan

Break the assignment into research, planning, drafting and checking tasks. Before submitting, compare your work with the brief and rubric and confirm the submission requirements.

7. Example

The task asks you to evaluate two pricing strategies and recommend one. You plan to explain each strategy, compare them against relevant criteria and justify your recommendation using evidence. You ask whether the recommendation should focus on a particular customer group before beginning your analysis.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I know the required action and scope.

☐ I understand the assessment criteria.

☐ I have checked unclear requirements.

☐ I have a plan and know how to submit.

9. When to seek further support

Ask your teacher about task requirements and disciplinary expectations. Ask an academic skills adviser about planning, structure or using evidence. If interpreting instructions remains difficult across tasks, ask about additional English-language support.

10.Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). Understanding your assignment. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports analysing instruction, content and limiting words and checking practical requirements.

RMIT University. (n.d.). Rubrics and learning outcomes. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports linking task expectations to learning outcomes, criteria and criterion weightings.

The six-step sequence, pricing example and planning question are toolkit adaptations. Follow the actual referencing style and tool rules specified for your course; examples in external resources are not your course requirements. Sources support particular elements rather than the complete guide. This guide is a draft for review and has not been evaluated with ethnic-minority students in Vietnamese higher education.